

PHISH CARNAGE: THE NEW ERA PHISHING DETECTION SYSTEM

*A
Synopsis
On
Phishing Detection System*

**in
COMPUTER SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING
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by

**KARTIK SRIVASTAVA (2401331720064)
KAUSHLENDRA SHUKLA (2401331720065)
ASHKAND KUMAR MISHRA (2401331720042)**

**Under the Supervision of
Mr. M. Abdul Mateen Siddiqui
Assistant Professor, Department of CSE (Cyber Security)**



**DEPARTMENT OF CSE (CYBER SECURITY)
SCHOOL OF COMPUTER SCIENCE IN EMERGING TECHNOLOGIES
NOIDA INSTITUTE OF ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGY,
GREATER NOIDA
(An Autonomous Institute)**

**Affiliated to
DR. A.P.J. ABDUL KALAM TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY, LUCKNOW
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ABSTRACT

Phishing attacks have become one of the most serious and widespread cyber security threats in the modern digital landscape. Attackers use deceptive techniques such as fake websites, fraudulent emails, and misleading messages to impersonate trusted organizations and trick users into sharing sensitive information, including usernames, passwords, financial details, and personal data. Traditional phishing detection methods, which mainly depend on static rules, predefined patterns, and blacklist-based approaches, often fail to identify newly created or modified phishing websites, making them less effective against evolving threats.

To overcome these challenges, this project proposes the design and development of a Machine Learning-based Phishing Detection Tool that provides intelligent and adaptive detection of malicious links. The system works by analyzing a variety of URL-based and website-related features such as domain structure, length of the URL, presence of suspicious characters, and other behavioral indicators. Using supervised machine learning techniques, the model is trained on labeled datasets containing both legitimate and phishing URLs, enabling it to learn meaningful patterns and distinguish between safe and malicious websites with higher accuracy.

Several machine learning algorithms, including Logistic Regression, Decision Tree, Random Forest, and Support Vector Machine (SVM), are implemented and evaluated in this project. These algorithms are compared based on performance metrics such as accuracy, precision, recall, and detection speed to identify the most effective model for real-time phishing detection.

Additionally, the proposed system can be integrated with a browser-based interface or extension to provide real-time protection for users while browsing the internet. When a user attempts to access a website, the tool automatically analyzes the URL using the trained machine learning model and classifies it as either legitimate or potentially malicious. If a phishing threat is detected, the system generates an alert to warn the user and prevent further interaction with the suspicious website.

INTRODUCTION :

The rapid growth of digital communication and online services has made daily life more convenient, but it has also increased the risk of cyber threats. Among these threats, phishing attacks have become one of the most common and harmful forms of cybercrime. In phishing attacks, users are misled into sharing sensitive information such as login credentials or financial details by fake emails, websites, or messages that appear legitimate.

Although several security measures exist, phishing techniques continue to evolve and often succeed in bypassing traditional, rule-based detection systems. Many users also find it difficult to identify fraudulent websites on their own. This situation highlights the need for smarter and more adaptive security solutions.

This project focuses on the design and development of a Phishing Detection Tool using Machine Learning techniques. The tool analyzes URL features and website characteristics to determine whether a link is legitimate or phishing, helping users make safer decisions in real time.

To achieve this objective, the proposed system utilizes supervised machine learning algorithms that are trained on datasets containing both legitimate and phishing URLs. By extracting important features such as URL length, domain characteristics, presence of special characters, and other structural indicators, the model learns patterns commonly associated with phishing attacks. Once trained, the system can automatically evaluate new URLs and classify them as safe or suspicious with improved accuracy. This approach not only enhances the effectiveness of phishing detection but also provides a scalable and intelligent solution to strengthen cybersecurity and protect users from emerging online threats.

PROBLEM STATEMENT :

Phishing attacks cause serious problems such as financial loss, identity theft, and unauthorized access to personal and organizational data. As attackers continuously modify their strategies, it becomes increasingly difficult for users to manually recognize phishing websites.

Most existing detection systems rely on static rules or blacklists, which are often ineffective against newly created phishing links. Therefore, there is a strong need for a dynamic and intelligent phishing detection system that can learn from data, adapt to new attack patterns, and provide reliable protection to users.

Another major challenge is the increasing sophistication of phishing websites. Modern phishing pages often closely resemble legitimate websites in terms of design, layout, and domain structure, making them difficult to distinguish from genuine platforms. Attackers frequently register new domains or slightly modify existing URLs to avoid detection by traditional security mechanisms. As a result, many phishing links remain active long enough to deceive users and compromise sensitive information before they are identified and blocked.

In addition, the rapid growth of online transactions, digital banking, and cloud-based services has significantly increased the number of potential targets for phishing attacks. Individuals and organizations depend heavily on the internet for communication and financial activities, which makes them more vulnerable to cyber threats. Without an intelligent detection system capable of analyzing suspicious patterns in real time, users remain exposed to phishing attempts that can lead to severe financial and reputational damage. Therefore, developing an advanced phishing detection approach is essential to enhance online security and protect users from evolving cyber threats.

OBJECTIVE :

- To study and understand common phishing techniques and attack patterns.
- To identify and extract important features from URLs and website attributes.
- To design and implement a machine learning–based classification model.
- To accurately classify websites as phishing or legitimate.
- To develop a simple and user-friendly interface for real-time detection.
- To increase user awareness and improve online security.

In addition to the technical objectives, the project also aims to evaluate the performance of different machine learning algorithms in detecting phishing websites. Various models can be compared using performance metrics such as accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score in order to determine the most reliable approach for identifying malicious links. This evaluation helps in selecting an optimal model that can provide effective and consistent phishing detection.

Furthermore, the project seeks to contribute to the development of proactive cybersecurity solutions that can adapt to emerging threats. By continuously learning from data and identifying suspicious patterns in URLs and website structures, the system can improve its detection capabilities over time. Such an intelligent approach not only strengthens protection against phishing attacks but also supports the creation of safer online environments for users and organizations.

FEASIBILITY STUDY :

A feasibility study is conducted to evaluate the practicality and viability of the proposed Machine Learning-based Phishing Detection Tool. The study analyzes the project from technical and economic perspectives to ensure that the system can be developed, deployed, and maintained effectively within available resources.

Technical Feasibility

The proposed project is technically feasible as it is built using well- established and widely supported technologies. The core machine learning models are developed using Python libraries such as Scikit-learn, NumPy, and Pandas, which provide efficient tools for data preprocessing, feature extraction, model training, and evaluation. These libraries are extensively used in both academic research and industry applications, ensuring reliability and ease of implementation.

Economic Feasibility

From an economic standpoint, the project is highly cost-effective. It relies entirely on open-source software tools and libraries, eliminating the need for expensive licensed software or proprietary platforms. Python, Scikit-learn, Flask, and other supporting tools are freely available, which significantly reduces development and deployment costs.

Moreover, the system does not require specialized or high-performance hardware, as the machine learning models can operate efficiently on existing computing resources. Maintenance costs are minimal due to the simplicity of the system architecture and the use of widely supported technologies. As a result, the overall development and operational expenses remain low, making the project economically viable for educational, research, and small- scale real-world applications.

REQUIREMENTS :

Functional Requirements

- The system shall accept a URL as input from the user.
- The system shall extract relevant URL and domain features.
- The system shall preprocess and normalize the extracted data.
- The system shall classify URLs as phishing or legitimate.
- The system shall display prediction results to the user.

Non-Functional Requirements

- High accuracy and reliability.
- Fast response time for real-time detection.
- Scalability to handle large numbers of URLs.
- Security of user input data.
- Compatibility with different platforms and browsers.

DESCRIPTION OF MODULES :

User Interface Module:

Provides a simple and interactive interface for users to enter URLs. Displays the classification result indicating whether the link is legitimate or phishing.

Feature Extraction Module:

Extracts key URL and website features such as URL length, special characters, domain age, and HTTPS usage.

These features help the system identify patterns commonly associated with phishing websites.

Preprocessing Module:

Cleans and prepares the data by handling missing values and removing inconsistencies.

Performs encoding, scaling, and normalization to improve model accuracy and performance.

Prediction and Alert Module:

Uses trained machine learning models to classify URLs in real time. Alerts users immediately when a phishing link is detected to prevent potential cyber threats.

Model Training and Evaluation Module:

This module is responsible for training the machine learning algorithms using a labeled dataset containing both legitimate and phishing URLs. During this stage, the extracted features are used to train different classification models such as Logistic Regression, Decision Tree, Random Forest, and Support Vector Machine. The performance of each model is evaluated using metrics such as accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score to determine the most effective model for phishing detection. The selected model is then deployed within the system to ensure reliable and efficient classification of suspicious links.

FUTURE SCOPE :

- Implementation of deep learning models for improved accuracy.
- Development of a browser extension for real-time detection.
- Integration of email phishing detection.
- Cloud-based deployment with API support.
- Continuous model training using live data.

In addition to these improvements, future work can focus on incorporating advanced feature extraction techniques that analyze not only URL characteristics but also webpage content, HTML structure, and visual similarity with legitimate websites. By examining these additional indicators, the system can detect more sophisticated phishing attempts that closely mimic trusted platforms. This would significantly enhance the accuracy and reliability of the phishing detection system.

Another potential enhancement is the integration of the phishing detection tool with mobile applications and security software. Since many users access websites through smartphones and other portable devices, extending the system's capabilities to mobile platforms would provide broader protection. Such integration could allow users to receive instant warnings when they encounter suspicious links while browsing, messaging, or using online applications.

Furthermore, future research may explore the use of collaborative threat intelligence and shared security databases. By connecting the system with global cybersecurity platforms, the detection tool could access updated threat information and newly discovered phishing patterns. This collaborative approach would help the system remain up to date with evolving cyber threats and improve its ability to identify newly emerging phishing attacks in real time.

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